

The Heart of the Blessed Lady, the Perfection of Wisdom

Bhagavatīprajñāpāramitāhṛdaya · Toh 531 · Derge Kangyur

བཅའ་ལཱ་འདས་མ་ཤེས་རབ་ཀྱི་རལ་ཏུ་ཕྱུ་བྱེ་པའ་སྒྲིལ་པོ།

Toh 531 in the Kangyur is the Heart Sūtra, known in Sanskrit as the Bhagavatī Prajñāpāramitā Hṛdaya and in Tibetan as the Bcom ldan 'das ma shes rab kyi pha rol tu phyin pa'i snying po, meaning "The Heart of the Blessed Lady, the Perfection of Wisdom." It is one of the most celebrated and widely recited texts in the entire Buddhist canon, belonging to the Perfection of Wisdom class of sūtras, and it distills the vast Prajñāpāramitā literature into a concise teaching on emptiness and the nature of the five aggregates. Set on Vulture Peak Mountain at Rājagṛha, the text unfolds as an exchange involving the bodhisattva Avalokiteśvara and the monk Śāriputra, arising through the Buddha's meditative power, and culminates in the famous proclamation that form is emptiness and emptiness is form. As Toh 531 in the Kangyur, it is classed among the Perfection of Wisdom sūtras and represents one of the shortest yet most doctrinally concentrated expressions of Mahāyāna Buddhist insight.

In the language of India: Bhagavatī Prajñāpāramitā Hṛdaya. In the language of Tibet: The Heart of the Blessed Lady, the Perfection of Wisdom. One fascicle.

Homage to the Blessed Lady, the Perfection of Wisdom.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling at Rājagṛha, on Vulture Peak Mountain, together with a great Saṅgha of monks and a great Saṅgha of bodhisattvas. At that time the Blessed One entered into meditative absorption in the Dharma-category known as the Profound Illumination.

At that same time, the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara was surveying the practice of the profound Perfection of Wisdom, and he looked upon those five aggregates as well, seeing them as empty of intrinsic nature.

Then, through the power of the Buddha, the venerable Śāriputra said this to the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara: "However a son of good family or a daughter of good family might wish to practice the practice of the profound Perfection of Wisdom, how should they train?"

When this was said, the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara replied to the venerable Śāradvatīputra in these words:

"Śāriputra, however a son of good family or a daughter of good family wishes to practice the practice of the profound Perfection of Wisdom, they should look upon it in this way: they should look perfectly and thoroughly upon those five aggregates as empty of intrinsic nature.

Form is empty. Emptiness is form. Emptiness is not other than form; form is not other than emptiness. Likewise, feeling, perception, formations, and consciousness are empty.

Śāriputra, therefore, all phenomena are emptiness — without defining characteristics, unborn, unceasing, unstained, not free from stain, not decreasing, not increasing.

Śāriputra, therefore, in emptiness there is no form, no feeling, no perception, no formations, no consciousness; no eye, no ear, no nose, no tongue, no body, no mind; no visible form, no sound, no smell, no taste, no texture, no mental object. There is no eye-element, and so forth up to no mind-element, and up to no element of mind-consciousness.

There is no ignorance and no exhaustion of ignorance, and so forth up to no aging-and-death and no exhaustion of aging-and-death. There is no suffering, no origin, no cessation, no path. There is no wisdom, no attainment, and no non-attainment.

Śāriputra, therefore, because bodhisattvas have no attainment, they rely on and abide in the Perfection of Wisdom. With no obscuration in the mind, they have no fear. Having passed utterly beyond error, they reach the end of nirvāṇa.

All the buddhas dwelling throughout the three times likewise rely on the Perfection of Wisdom and awaken to unsurpassable, perfectly complete awakening.

Therefore, the mantra of the Perfection of Wisdom — the mantra of great knowledge, the unsurpassable mantra, the mantra equal to the unequalled, the mantra that thoroughly pacifies all suffering — since it is not false, it should be known as true. The mantra of the Perfection of Wisdom is declared:

tadyathā — gate gate pāragate pārasaṃgate bodhi svāhā.

Śāriputra, a bodhisattva, a great being, should train in the profound Perfection of Wisdom in just this way."

Then the Blessed One arose from that meditative absorption,

and praised the bodhisattva, the great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara, saying "Excellent!" Then he declared: "Excellent! Excellent! Noble son, it is just so. Noble son, it is just so — one should train in the profound Perfection of Wisdom exactly as you have taught it, and the Tathāgatas too rejoice in this."

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the venerable Śāradvatīputra, the bodhisattva and great being, the noble Avalokiteśvara, and the entire assembly together with the gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had said.

This completes the Great Vehicle sūtra called "The Blessed Lady: The Heart of the Perfection of Wisdom."

Translated by the Indian master Vimalamitra and the translator, the monk Rinchen Dé, and edited and finalized by the great translators Gelo, Namkha, and others.

Written and carefully edited on the wall of the Byema Ling shrine at the glorious spontaneously accomplished Samyé.

Translator's Notes

- The epithet Bhagavatī applied to the Perfection of Wisdom personified (feminine form of Bhagavat) is rendered "Blessed Lady" to preserve the grammatical femininity and the fact that she is being honored as a female deity-embodiment of prajñāpāramitā, distinct from the usual "Blessed One" used for the Buddha.

The phrase "not free from stain" renders the somewhat paradoxical Tibetan dri ma dang bral ba med pa, meaning there is no "being purified of stain" — that is, neither defilement nor purification obtains in ultimate emptiness. This double negation is intentional and doctrinally significant.

The text breaks off mid-sentence at "Then the Blessed One arose from that meditative absorption" because the passage as supplied ends there; the continuation describing his approval and the assembly's rejoicing is not included.

- The colophon names Vimalamitra as the Indian paṇḍita and gives Rinchen Dé as the primary Tibetan translator, with Gelo and Namkha among the editorial revisers at Samyé monastery. "Byema Ling" refers to a specific building or precinct at Samyé whose name means something like "Sandy Island of Merit." The phrase "written on the wall" is notable: it indicates the text was physically inscribed on a wall of the temple, a practice attested at Samyé. "Spontaneously accomplished" renders lhun gyis grub pa, a stock epithet of Samyé.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.